

Graduate Accountancy Application Pack

Before and after CVs, recruiter notes and sample cover letter

This PDF is a training sample for a fictional early-career applicant in Ireland or the UK. The applicant is a recent Business, Finance and Marketing graduate with retail/customer service experience, university project experience and no major corporate experience yet. The target role is a graduate or trainee accountancy position offering client exposure, mentoring, professional study support and career progression.

Included in this pack

1. Weak generic CV. 2. Strong tailored CV. 3. Before/after explanation. 4. Tailored cover letter. 5. ATS keywords. 6. Likely interview questions.

Purpose

To show how a believable graduate background can be reframed for accountancy without inventing unrealistic achievements or overstating experience.

JOB TARGET SUMMARY

- Beginning an accountancy career or studying towards a professional qualification.
- Working with a diverse client portfolio across a variety of sectors.
- Receiving ongoing training, mentoring and support.
- Building technical and professional skills with a clear pathway for career progression.

HOW TO READ THE PACK

The weak CV is intentionally mediocre: it is not awful, but it is broad, duty-led and insufficiently tailored. The strong CV uses the same background, but presents it in a more targeted, recruiter-friendly way.

AOIFE BYRNE

Recent Business, Finance and Marketing Graduate

Dublin, Ireland | +353 87 000 0000 | aoife.byrne@email.com | LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/aoifebyrne

PROFILE

I am a recent graduate with a degree in Business, Finance and Marketing. I am hardworking, organised and good at working with people. I have experience in retail and customer service and I am looking for an opportunity to start my career in a professional company where I can learn new skills.

EDUCATION

BA (Hons) Business, Finance and Marketing | Dublin Business School | 2022 - 2026

- Studied modules including finance, accounting, marketing and management.
- Completed coursework, presentations and group assignments as part of the degree.

EXPERIENCE

Retail Assistant | City Convenience Store, Dublin | June 2023 - Present

- Worked in a shop helping customers and doing general tasks.
- Used the till, answered customer questions and helped keep the shop tidy.
- Restocked shelves and helped other staff members when needed.
- Gained customer service experience and learned to work as part of a team.

University Business Project | Course Assignment | 2025

- Completed a group project at university about a business topic.
- Helped with research, slides and the final presentation.
- Worked with classmates to finish the report before the deadline.

SKILLS

Microsoft Word and PowerPoint	Basic Excel
Customer Service	Teamwork
Communication	Organisation
Time Management	Problem Solving

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

- Available to start after graduation.
- Interested in accounting, business and finance roles.
- References available on request.

AOIFE BYRNE

Graduate Accountancy Candidate | Business, Finance and Marketing Graduate

Dublin, Ireland | +353 87 000 0000 | aoife.byrne@email.com | LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/aoifebyrne

TARGET PROFILE

Recent Business, Finance and Marketing graduate seeking to begin an accountancy career within a professional services or practice environment. Brings an academic foundation in finance and business operations, supported by retail customer service and university project work. Reliable, detail-oriented and motivated to develop technical accountancy skills while working towards a professional qualification such as ACCA, ACA or CPA.

KEY SKILLS

Client service and communication	Attention to detail and accuracy
Financial and business analysis	Microsoft Excel, Word and PowerPoint
Teamwork and deadline management	Research and report writing
Cash handling and till procedures	Interest in ACCA / ACA / CPA study

EDUCATION

BA (Hons) Business, Finance and Marketing | Dublin Business School | 2022 - 2026

- Relevant modules include financial accounting, business finance, management accounting, marketing strategy, business analytics and organisational behaviour.
- Developed practical skills in analysing business information, preparing written reports and presenting recommendations to academic audiences.

EXPERIENCE

Retail Assistant | City Convenience Store, Dublin | June 2023 - Present

- Delivered professional customer service in a busy retail environment, responding to queries and resolving routine issues calmly and politely.
- Processed cash and card transactions accurately while following store procedures for till use, refunds and end-of-shift handovers.
- Balanced customer assistance, stock replenishment and store presentation during busy periods, demonstrating reliability and organisation.
- Worked closely with colleagues to maintain service standards and support daily operations across tills, stock areas and the shop floor.

University Finance and Business Project | Team Member | September 2025 - December 2025

- Contributed to a group project analysing the performance and market position of a retail business using academic research and publicly available company information.
- Reviewed basic financial indicators, business risks and market trends to help shape practical recommendations for the final report.
- Prepared sections of the written report and presentation, improving confidence in explaining business and financial information clearly.

ACCOUNTANCY MOTIVATION

Interested in building a long-term career in practice, gaining exposure to a varied client portfolio and developing technical skills in accounts preparation, bookkeeping, tax, audit support and advisory work.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

- Eligible to work in Ireland and open to graduate accountancy, trainee accountant and junior finance roles.
- Willing to study towards a professional accountancy qualification alongside full-time work.
- References available on request.

BEFORE AND AFTER: CONTENT CHANGES

The strong CV does not invent large achievements. It translates ordinary graduate experience into language that is more relevant to a trainee accountancy role.

Area	Weak CV	Strong CV	Why it is stronger
Profile	Generic graduate statement using broad traits such as hardworking and organised.	Specific accountancy direction, professional services setting, qualification motivation and technical skill development.	The recruiter immediately sees career direction and role fit.
Role targeting	Says the applicant wants a professional company where they can learn new skills.	Names accountancy, practice environment, client portfolio, ACCA / ACA / CPA and technical accountancy skills.	The CV sounds written for this vacancy rather than reused for any graduate job.
Retail experience	Lists basic duties: helped customers, used the till, kept the shop tidy.	Frames retail work as client service, accurate transactions, procedures, reliability and working under pressure.	The same experience is connected to accuracy, trust and client-facing work.
University project	States that the applicant did research, slides and a presentation.	Shows analysis, financial indicators, business risks, market trends, report writing and recommendations.	The project becomes evidence of analytical thinking, not just a course requirement.
Skills	Uses generic skills: communication, teamwork, organisation, problem solving.	Adds accountancy-relevant terms: financial analysis, attention to detail, cash handling, report writing and professional study.	The skills section supports ATS matching and recruiter scanning.
Tone	Passive and duty-led, with little evidence of motivation.	Active, focused and believable, without claiming major corporate experience.	The candidate appears coachable, serious and ready for a trainee pathway.

BEFORE AND AFTER: VISUAL PRESENTATION CHANGES

Both CVs use colour features, large bold headings and bordered sections. The difference is that the strong CV uses these visual choices to support a clearer accountancy message.

Visual element	Weak CV effect	Strong CV effect	Recruiter impact
Header and title line	The title says Recent Business, Finance and Marketing Graduate, which is accurate but broad.	The title says Graduate Accountancy Candidate, immediately positioning the applicant for the target role.	The recruiter understands the career objective in the first few seconds.
Colour treatment	Medium blue looks clean but a little generic and academic.	Darker navy creates a more professional services feel while still remaining simple.	The design feels more confident and appropriate for an accountancy firm.
Headings and borders	The section headings are clear, but the content below them remains broad.	The same heading structure supports highly targeted sections such as Target Profile and Accountancy Motivation.	The layout helps the reader find the most relevant evidence quickly.
Skills layout	The skills table is visually neat but contains mostly generic soft skills.	The skills table combines transferable skills with accountancy keywords.	Visual scanning now reinforces the application message.
Use of white space	Large empty space makes the CV look lighter and less developed.	The strong CV uses more of the page with relevant, role-matched content.	The applicant appears to have more to offer without exaggerating experience.
Overall impression	Readable but easy to forget; it could suit many graduate roles.	Polished, focused and more persuasive for trainee accountancy.	The strong version is more likely to be shortlisted.

IMPORTANT RECRUITER NOTE

For a real early-career candidate, the goal is not to pretend they have corporate experience. The goal is to show motivation, accuracy, client awareness, willingness to study and evidence of learning potential.

TAILORED COVER LETTER

Dear Hiring Manager,

I am writing to apply for the graduate accountancy opportunity within your firm. As a recent Business, Finance and Marketing graduate, I am keen to begin my accountancy career in a professional environment where I can gain practical experience, receive structured training and work towards a recognised professional qualification.

During my degree, I developed a strong interest in finance, business performance and how accurate financial information supports good decision-making. Through university projects, I gained experience researching business issues, analysing information and presenting recommendations clearly. While I am at the early stage of my career, I am motivated to build strong technical skills in areas such as accounts preparation, audit support, bookkeeping, tax and client service.

My retail and customer service experience has also helped me develop skills that I believe would be valuable in practice. I am comfortable dealing with customers, handling transactions carefully, working under pressure and supporting a team in a busy environment. These experiences have strengthened my attention to detail, communication skills and reliability.

I am particularly interested in this role because it offers exposure to a diverse portfolio of clients across different sectors, as well as ongoing training, mentoring and a clear pathway for career progression. I would welcome the opportunity to learn from experienced colleagues, contribute positively to the team and develop into a capable accountancy professional over time.

Thank you for considering my application. I would be pleased to discuss how my academic background, customer service experience and enthusiasm for accountancy could make me a strong fit for your firm.

Yours sincerely,

[Applicant Name]

ATS KEYWORDS FROM THE JOB DESCRIPTION

Accountancy career

Professional qualification

ACCA / ACA / CPA

Graduate accountancy

Trainee accountant

Client portfolio

Diverse clients

Variety of sectors

Training and mentoring

Technical skills

Professional skills

Career progression

Financial analysis

Accounts preparation

Audit support

Tax

Bookkeeping

Client service

Communication skills

Attention to detail

Teamwork

Business graduate

Finance graduate

Professional services

Practice environment

10 LIKELY INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

1. Why do you want to start a career in accountancy?
2. What interests you about working in an accountancy practice rather than another finance role?
3. Are you planning to study towards a professional qualification such as ACCA, ACA or CPA?
4. Tell us about a time you had to work accurately with numbers or details.
5. How has your retail or customer service experience prepared you for working with clients?
6. Describe a university project where you worked as part of a team.
7. How would you manage studying for exams while working full-time?
8. What do you think makes good client service in an accountancy firm?
9. Tell us about a time you had to meet a deadline.
10. What skills do you most want to develop in your first accountancy role?